

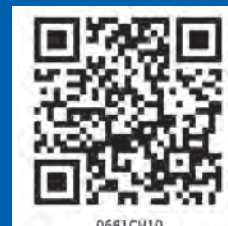
“The ruler protects dharma and dharma protects those who protect it.”

*“There is no peace without justice;
no justice without equality;
no equality without development;
no democracy without respect to the identity
and dignity of cultures and peoples.”*

Rigoberta Menchú Tum

The Big Questions ?

1. What is the meaning of 'governance'?
2. Why do we need a government?
3. What is the meaning of 'democracy'? Why is it important?



Introduction

Human beings have been living in communities for a long time. When a large number of people live together, there can be disagreements and disorder, and rules become necessary to maintain order and harmony in the society.

There are probably some simple rules at home that you are expected to follow. The school where you study has rules too — some for students, others for teachers. In higher classes, students appearing for examinations must follow certain rules. Drivers on the road are expected to obey traffic rules. People employed in all kinds of jobs also need to follow the rules set by their employer, while the employers must also follow rules which they have committed to their employees.

What would happen if no one followed those rules? A simple answer is that society would not be able to function.

LET'S EXPLORE



- Describe the two pictures given in Fig. 10.1 on page 151 — what differences do you see between them?
- How do you connect this with our discussion on rules?
- What are some of the rules in your school? Who made them?

Who makes the rules and why? How are they made? These are some of the questions we will explore in this chapter. The process of taking decisions, organising the society's life with different sets of rules, and ensuring that they are followed, is called **governance**. The group of individuals or the system that makes the rules and ensures that they are followed is called a **government**. Some of the more important rules are called **laws**.

This does not mean that rules and laws are set once and for all. Just as you might discuss a particular rule at home with your parents, or as a student body might ask the school or

university management to change a rule, citizens also have a say in the laws and rules governing the society. We will see how this takes place.



Fig. 10.1



Fig. 10.2

LET'S EXPLORE

- Can you identify the categories of public service or other activities that are represented in the ten pictures in Fig. 10.2 on page 152?
- What role do you think the government plays in each of these activities?
- Can you think of other aspects of your daily life where the government plays an important role?



Three Organs of Government

All over the world, digital technologies have been transforming the way societies function. In India, till about 30 years ago, people who wanted to transfer money to a distant relative would have to queue up at the Post Office to send a money order after filling up a form; or if they had to send a payment to some business, they would queue up at their bank to obtain a demand draft, which would then have to be sent by post. You have probably never heard these terms ('money order' or 'demand draft'), because today we have digital means of sending across money instantly!

However, this has also created a new class of criminals who, without even leaving their desks, find digital ways of stealing people's money. This has led many governments to pass new laws in order to fight such criminal activities (called 'cybercrime'). Some of those criminals, who believe in robbing innocent people of their hard-earned money instead of using their skills to contribute to the society, have been arrested and convicted in court. They are usually fined as well as jailed for some years.

Through this example, we can see how the three branches or 'organs' of a government work together:

- The **legislature** is the organ that makes new laws (or 'legislates'). Sometimes it also updates or removes

existing laws. This is done by an assembly of representatives of the people. We will soon see how the Indian system works.

- The **executive** is the organ that implements (or ‘executes’) the laws. This includes the head of state (who may be a president, a prime minister or a chief minister), the ministers and any agency responsible for enforcing ‘law and order’. (In our example above, that agency is the cyber police.)
- The **judiciary** is the system of courts which decides whether someone has broken the law and, if so, what course of action should be taken, including punishment if necessary. Sometimes it also examines whether a decision taken by the executive is right, or whether a law passed by the legislature is well conceived and fair to all.



LET'S EXPLORE

Explain how the three government organs are at work in the case of the cybercriminals described above. How do they intervene?

In a good system of governance, these three organs must be kept separate, although they interact with each other and work together. This separation is called the ‘**separation of powers**’ (Fig. 10.3). It is intended to provide a system of checks and balances. This means that each organ of the government can check what the other is doing and restore balance if one organ acts beyond its expected role.

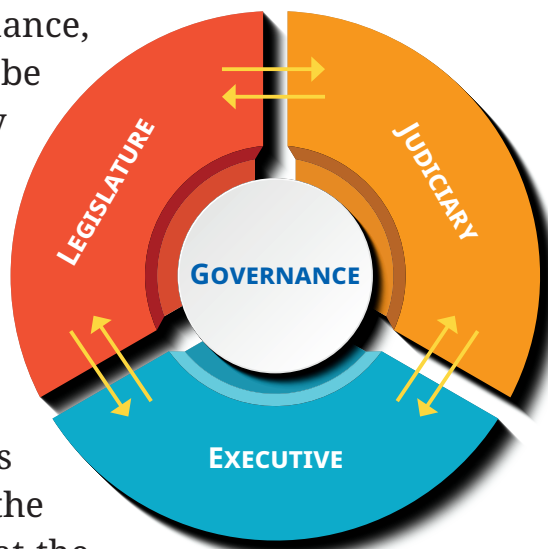


Fig. 10.3

LET'S EXPLORE

As a class activity, can you imagine the sort of disorder we might witness if all three organs were under the control of the same group of people? Can you describe any such real-life situation you may have heard of?



Three Levels of Government

Any government operates at two levels at the least — local and national. In many countries, including India, it functions at three levels or tiers — local, state or regional, and national. Each level deals with different matters. To use a comparison, if a bulb in your home is not lighting up, you will first check the bulb, switch, fuse, etc. If that does not work, you may call an electrician, and if it is found that the problem is not within your home, you may need to go to the Electricity Board and file a complaint. These are also three levels of dealing with a problem.

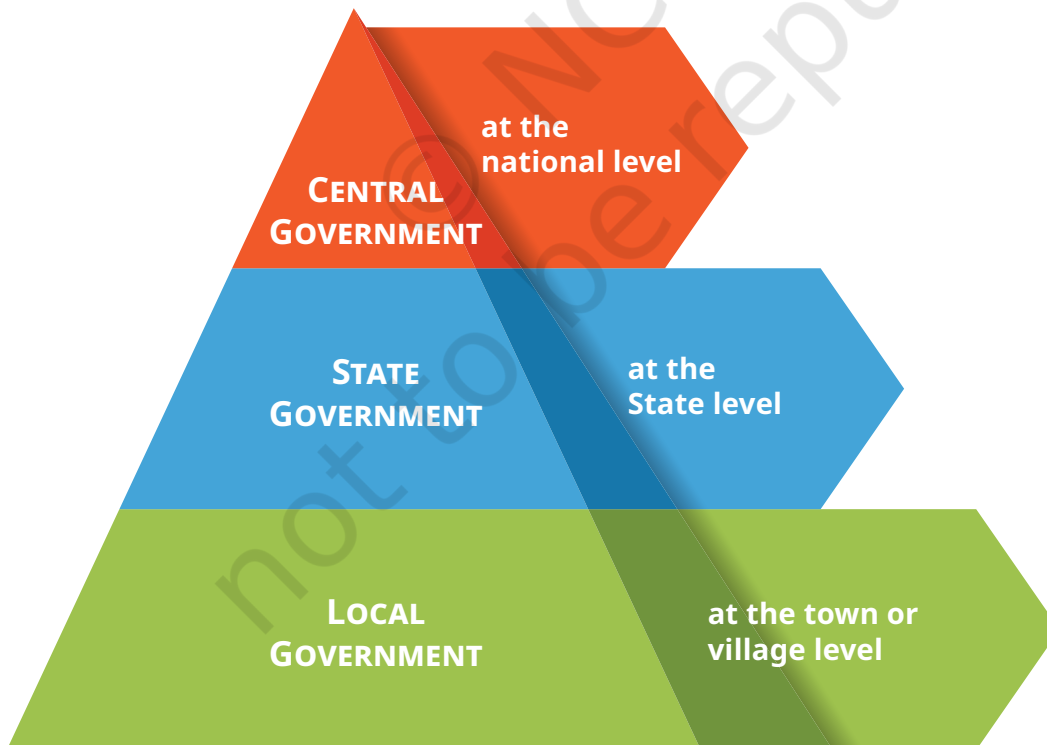


Fig. 10.4

In India, we have local governments, State governments, and Central or Union government (Fig. 10.4 on page 155). Imagine that following heavy rain for a few days, there is a flood in a part of a district. If it is not too severe, the local authorities may be able to deal with it. If it involves several towns and many villages, the State Government will step in and send rescue teams to help affected people. But if it's a massive flood affecting vast areas, the Central Government may also come to help by sending relief supplies, the army, etc. These are the three levels again.



DON'T MISS OUT

Many of our institutions have mottos inspired by the wisdom of our ancient texts. The Government of India's motto, for example, is *Satyameva Jayate*, which means "Truth alone triumphs". The Supreme Court's motto is *Yato Dharmastato Jayah*, or, "Where there is dharma, there is victory."

The table on the facing page provides in summary a general framework of the main functions of the government's three organs at the national and State levels. Their details (including the precise role of the assemblies) will be studied in greater depth in Grade 7. (Local government is not mentioned here as we will look at it more closely in the next two chapters.)



LET'S EXPLORE

- Observe the table (Fig. 10.5). Highlight the functions and responsibilities that affect your life the most.
- Ask two or three adults about their connection or interaction with the government – at what levels does it take place and for what purpose?

	ALL INDIA	STATE LEVEL
Judiciary	Supreme Court of India	High Court

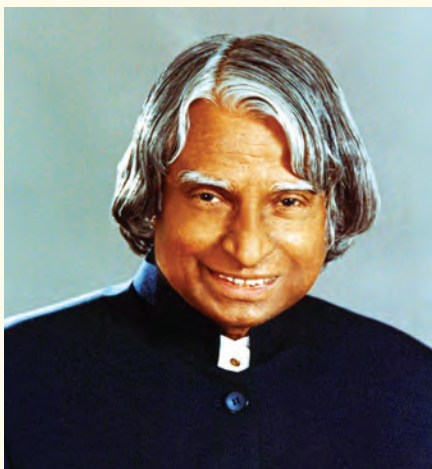
	NATIONAL LEVEL	STATE LEVEL
Legislature	Two houses – Lok Sabha and Rajya Sabha – formulate national laws	One State Assembly or Vidhan Sabha (Note that most States have a single assembly; a few States have two)

House:
An assembly where laws are discussed or passed.

Nominal: In name only. It means, in our case, that the President of India and the Governor of a State are not the actual executive heads. They do have certain powers under special circumstances, but normally do not interfere in the affairs of the Central or State government.

	CENTRAL GOVERNMENT	STATE GOVERNMENT
Executive	Led by the President of India (nominal head and Supreme Commander of the Indian Armed Forces), Prime Minister as the executive head	Led by the Governor (nominal head), Chief Minister as the executive head
Functions and responsibilities of the Executive (the list is not exhaustive)	• Defence • Foreign Affairs • Atomic Energy • Communications • Currency • Interstate Commerce • Education • Formulation of National Policies	• Police, law and order • Adaptation and implementation of laws made by the Central government at the State level. • Public health • Education • Agriculture • Irrigation • Local government

Fig. 10.5



Dr. A.P.J. Abdul Kalam

Born in a humble family in Rameswaram, Tamil Nadu, in 1931, Dr. A.P.J. Abdul Kalam was a renowned scientist, nicknamed the 'Missile Man of India' for his crucial role in the development of India's space programme, missile programme and nuclear capabilities.

Dr. Abdul Kalam served as the 11th President of India from 2002 to 2007. Despite his high status, he remained deeply connected to the people, and the youth in particular, through his passion for good education and innovation. He inspired millions with his humility, dedication to social causes and commitment to the nation. He tirelessly encouraged young Indians to dream big and work hard to achieve their goals.

Dr. Kalam showed that even though his position as the President of India was nominal, he could play an important role, impacting countless lives.

Let us meditate on a few of his inspiring thoughts:

"Look at the sky. We are not alone. The whole universe is friendly to us and conspires only to give the best to those who dream and work."

"To succeed in your mission, you must have single-minded devotion to your goal."

"If you fail, never give up because F.A.I.L. means 'First Attempt In Learning'. End is not the end, in fact E.N.D. means 'Effort Never Dies'. If you get 'no' as an answer, remember N.O. means 'Next Opportunity'. So let's be positive."

"Dream is not that which you see while sleeping; it is something that does not let you sleep."

"If four things are followed — having a great aim, acquiring knowledge, hard work, and perseverance — then anything can be achieved."

Democracy

You may have noticed that we earlier mentioned ‘representatives of the people’. This is one of the foundation stones of the system of governance adopted by most countries of the world — **democracy**. The word ‘democracy’ comes from two Greek words — *dēmos* meaning ‘people’, and *kratos* meaning ‘rule’ or ‘power’; so ‘democracy’ literally means the ‘rule of the people’.

But can all people actually rule? It is clearly not possible. Imagine there is a problem that your class wants to bring to the attention of your school’s principal — maybe there is something wrong with the classroom, or with the school’s infrastructure, or perhaps you would like to propose a certain date for a field trip. Will the entire class go to the principal? It would clearly not be practical. In many schools, classes have a ‘class monitor’ or ‘class representative’, whom the whole class elected; even if there is none, one representative can be selected for this specific purpose. It will be enough to send the representative to the principal.

It is the same principle at the State or national levels — through elections, people vote for **representatives**, who will be the elected members of their respective assemblies. They are generally called ‘**Members of Legislative Assembly**’ (or MLAs) at the State level, and ‘**Member of Parliament**’ (or MPs) at the national level.

All these members discuss laws, problems and solutions in the assemblies, and, through dialogue and debate, try to convince each other whenever there are different opinions.

Like any modern democracy, therefore, India is a **representative democracy**. It is also the world’s



largest democracy, with some 970 million voters in 2024! In principle, all Indian citizens above the age of 18 have the right to participate in these elections.

Imagine that your class is planning to go for a picnic. There are two possible places, A and B. The class discusses the pros and cons — distance, time, cost, availability of basic facilities, etc. It becomes difficult to arrive at a decision. So your teacher decides that voting can solve the problem. The number of students in favour of place A raise their hands, then the number of students in favour of place B raise theirs. The decision is taken by whichever option gets a larger number of raised hands. (This process is called voting.) This is a case of **direct democracy** where every student's opinion was taken to finalise the place.

The term **grassroots democracy** refers to a system that enables and encourages the participation of ordinary citizens — the base of the pyramid we saw in Fig. 10.4 on page 155. In such a system, the citizens can have a say in decisions which affect them.

We will study more features of Indian democracy in the next two chapters and also in later grades.



Before we move on ...

- No country can run without governance and government.
- A modern government has three organs — legislative, executive and judiciary — which need to work together.
- The Indian government functions at three levels — Centre or national, State and local.
- Democracy is the overall framework for this system. It functions through elected representatives, both at the State and the national levels.

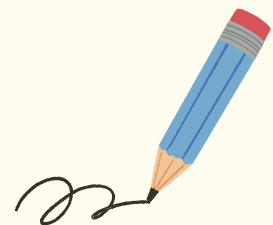
Questions, activities and projects

1. Test yourself — What is the meaning of democracy? What is the difference between direct democracy and representative democracy?
2. Recall the three organs of government. What are their different roles?
3. Why do we need three tiers of government?
4. Project: Many of you will remember the lockdown that took place during the COVID-19 pandemic. Make a list of all the actions that were taken at that time? Which tiers of government were involved in managing the situation? What was the role of each of the organs of government?

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*'Noodles' is our abbreviation for 'Notes and Doodles'!



Grassroots Democracy – Part 2

Local Government in Rural Areas



The real India lives in its villages.

– M.K. Gandhi



The Big Questions ?

1. What are Panchayati Raj institutions?
2. What are their functions?
3. Why are they important in governance and democracy?



0681CH11

Let us now see how the government functions at the local level. In this chapter, our focus will be on local government in rural areas; we will move to urban areas in the next chapter.

India is a country of enormous size and diversity. We have about 600,000 villages, 8,000 towns and over 4,000 cities. Our population has crossed 1.4 billion, almost two-thirds of which live in rural areas. How do we govern ourselves in this complex society?

Let us take a trip to Lakshmanpur, a small village in the foothills of the Himalayas. It has 200 houses and a population of about 700, most of whom are farmers. People cultivate



their lands and rear cows or goats. Some have relatives serving in the armed forces; a few younger villagers have migrated to the city in search of jobs. What are the needs of this village — maybe water for the fields, repairing the main road if it got damaged by heavy rains, or maintaining the village's primary school? How will the villagers take decisions about such matters that affect their daily lives? And where will they get the resources to meet those needs? What will happen if there is a dispute about land or if some of the crop is stolen? Many such questions can arise in a village. Can people run to the State or the national capital for every such issue?

Panchayati Raj System

Like every village in India, the Lakshmanpur people have a system of **local** government called 'Panchayat', which refers to a village council. Panchayats bring governance closer to the people, making it possible for them to actively participate in decision-making processes. That is why the Panchayat system, also known as **Panchayati Raj**, is a form of **self-government**. Panchayats play a vital role in addressing local issues, promoting development and ensuring that the benefits of government schemes reach the grassroots level.

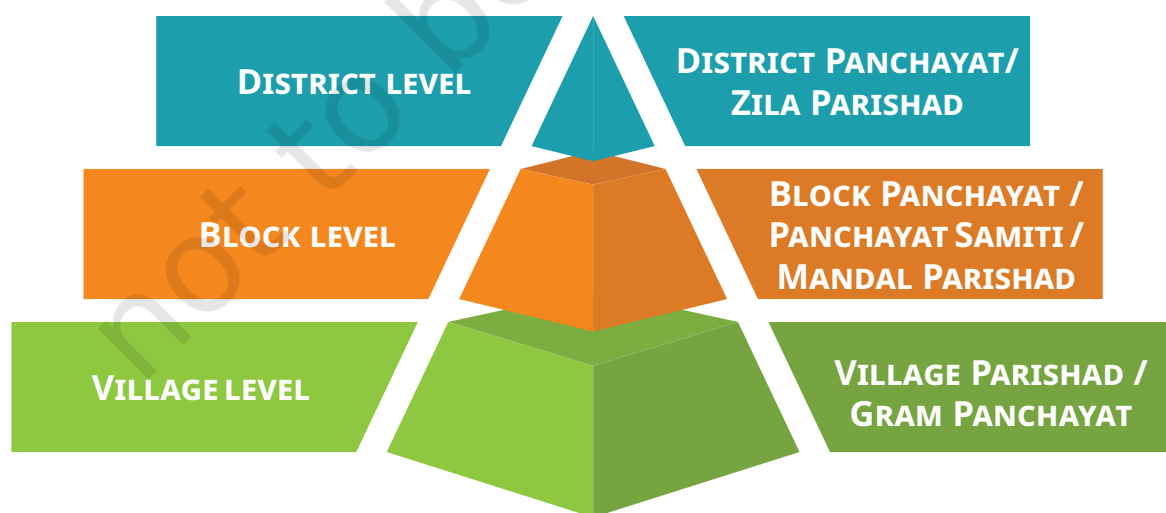


Fig. 11.1

As is clear from the diagram, the Panchayati Raj system works at three levels — from bottom up — the village, the block and the district. This is called a **‘three-tier system’**. Together, these institutions’ responsibilities cover almost all aspects of life in the district, from agriculture, housing, maintenance of roads, management of water resources, education, health care and social welfare to cultural activities.

Gram Panchayat

Let us begin with the base of Fig. 11.1 on page 164 — the Gram Panchayat, which is closest to the people in rural areas. Its members are elected directly by the Gram Sabha, which is a group of adults from a village (or group of neighbouring villages) who are enrolled as voters. In the Gram Sabha, women and men discuss all matters related to their area and take decisions. Each Gram Panchayat elects a head or president called the ‘Sarpanch’ or ‘Pradhan’. In recent years, more and more women have become Sarpanchs.



Exemplary Sarpanchs



Dnyaneshwar Kamble is a transgender person who was elected Sarpanch of Tarangfal village in the Solapur district of Maharashtra in 2017. Kamble's motto is *lok seva, gram seva*, that is, 'Service to the village is service to the public.' Kamble defeated six other candidates to become the Sarpanch.

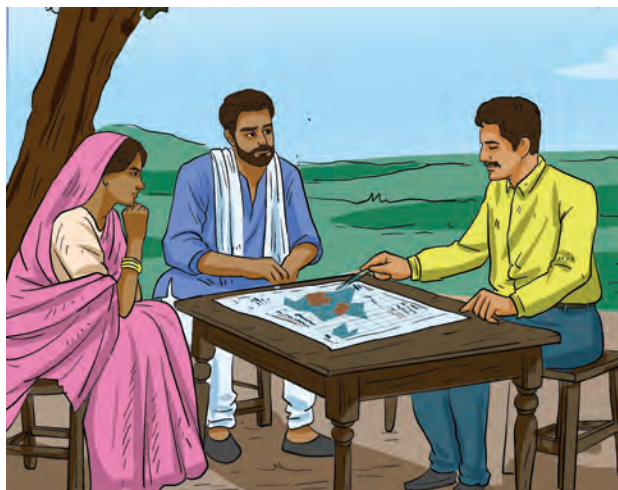
Vandana Bahadur Maida, a member of the Bhil community from the village of Khankhandvi in Madhya Pradesh, defied

patriarchal norms to become the first female Sarpanch of her village. She convinced women in the village to attend the Sabha meetings and addressed critical issues like education and sanitation, earning recognition far and wide. Vandana's journey shows how women can play a leading role in transforming rural India.



Hiware Bazar, a village in Ahmednagar district of Maharashtra, used to be affected by frequent droughts and poor agricultural yield. After **Popatrao Baguji Pawar** became its Sarpanch, he started applying Anna Hazare's model of rainwater harvesting, watershed conservation and massive tree planting of lakhs of trees, all of which contributed to the recharge of groundwater. With the collaboration of the villagers, Hiware Bazar became a green and prosperous village in a few years. Shri Popatrao Pawar was awarded the Padma Shri in 2020.

The Gram Panchayat is assisted by a Panchayat Secretary who performs administrative functions such as calling meetings and maintaining records. Most Gram Panchayats are also assisted by an officer called 'Patwari' in many parts of India, who maintains the villagers' land records. In some cases, the Patwari keeps maps that are generations old!



THINK ABOUT IT

How do you think can these old maps be helpful for us?
Can they tell us something about the past and the present?

Child-Friendly Panchayat Initiative

Panchayats are supposed to listen to everyone's voice — including the voice of children. The Child-Friendly Panchayat Initiative creates opportunities for children to express their ideas and opinions on matters that concern their wellbeing. Steps are being taken in several States to encourage the participation of children in Bal Sabhas and Bal Panchayats on a regular basis, while village elders try to find solutions to their concerns.

In Maharashtra, for example, a few Bal Panchayats have worked to eliminate child labour and child marriage. They have brought many children back to school. The Bal Panchayat members get together to convince parents and other adults to send their wards back to school, and not to arrange marriages for girls who should be studying.

Several Gram Panchayats have won awards for taking child-friendly initiatives. Here's an example from Sikkim:

Sangkhu Radhu Khandu Gram Panchayat, in west Sikkim, has given a lot of importance to children's needs and rights.

The Panchayat has built compound walls for schools to make them safer for children. To ensure that students get hygienically cooked midday meals, the Gram Panchayat has constructed kitchens in the schools. It is for these efforts that Sangkhu Radhu Khandu has been declared a child-friendly Gram Panchayat.

Let us also look at another example from Rajasthan:

The 'Children's Parliament', an offshoot of Bunker Roy's 'Barefoot College' initiative a few decades ago, empowered underprivileged children in Rajasthan's rural areas through education and democratic participation. Children aged 8 to 14 are engaged in governance processes, learning about democracy and social responsibility through night schools and parliament-like elections. The 'Parliament' followed formal procedures, including voter ID cards and campaigning. Elected representatives formed a 'Cabinet', overseeing school management and advocating for community needs. The initiative fostered leadership skills and social awareness, enabling children to challenge societal norms and advocate for change. Children actively addressed issues such as access to education, sanitation and



social equality, contributing to community development. The Children's Parliament initiative received many accolades, including the World's Children's Honorary Award in 2001.

LET'S EXPLORE

As a class activity, let four or five students form a Bal Panchayat and the rest of the class imagine they are the villagers. What issues will the Gram Sabha discuss? What challenges could it encounter? What solutions will it propose?



Panchayat Samiti and Zila Parishad

Similar institutions exist at the block level and the district level, which are above the village level. Their names are listed in the pyramidal diagram we saw in Fig. 11.1 on page 164. The Panchayat Samiti at the block level is the link between the Gram Panchayat and the Zila Parishad at the district level. The members of these institutions are elected by the local people, but they may have other members like Sarpanchs of the villages in the area and local members of the State Legislative Assembly.

The composition of the Panchayat Samitis differs from State to State, but their role in strengthening the participation of local people remains the same. They coordinate matters across Gram Panchayats, for instance, by collecting development plans from all Gram Panchayats and putting them together to present them at the District or State levels respectively. This facilitates the allotment of funds for such development projects and for government schemes such as the Pradhan Mantri Gram Sadak Yojana, which promotes the construction of all-weather roads in rural areas.

At all the three levels, special rules have been made so that disadvantaged sections of the population can make their needs and problems heard. These institutions also have a provision for reserving one-third of the seats for women.

**THINK ABOUT IT**

Why do you think it is important for the government to pay more attention to the needs and problems of the disadvantaged sections of society?

**LET'S EXPLORE**

- What similarities and differences do you notice between the governance system at the Central level and at the Panchayat level? (*Hint: refer back to Chapter 10 if required.*)
- If you get an opportunity to meet a few Panchayat members, what questions would you like to ask them? Discuss in small groups to create a questionnaire. Meet some Gram Panchayat members or invite them to your school. Ask them the questions in your questionnaire and write a short report.

Let us remember that the structure and functions of the Panchayati Raj institutions differ a little across States. This is because the States have authority over those institutions. But their objectives are the same — it is to enable villagers to take an active part in the management and development of their villages and the local area.

The *Arthaśhāstra* is an ancient text of governance written by Kauṭilya (later also known as Chāṇakya) some 2,300 years ago. Among other things, it describes how a state should be structured and run, how the economy can be made prosperous, what the duties of the ruler are and how to conduct war. Kauṭilya, an expert in statecraft, also explains how a whole administrative structure should be put in place from the village to the regional capital:

“The king shall establish a *sangrahaṇa* (a sub-district head quarters) for every 10 villages; a *kārvaṭika* (district headquarters) for every 100 villages; a *droṇamukha* for every 400 villages; and a *sthānīya* (provincial headquarters) for every 800 villages.”

In today’s language, what are the names we would give these four categories? Is it not amazing that a similar structure was thought of so long ago?

Before we move on ...



- The local government in rural areas is organised into a three-tier system.
- Democracy in the Panchayati Raj system works both through direct participation of people and through their elected representatives.
- The Panchayati Raj institutions give people in rural areas a measure of self-governance, so they may manage their issues and collaborate in development plans.

Questions, activities and projects

1. Test yourself — without looking at the text above, can you name the three tiers of the Panchayati Raj system? What are the key functions of each of the three tiers?
2. Write a letter to the Sarpanch regarding the issue of plastic bags lying on the roadside in the village.
3. In your view, what type of person should be a Gram Panchayat member?
4. Let us suppose that you study in a village school. The school is located next to a highway and students find it difficult to cross the road when they come to school or leave at the end of the day. What are the options to solve this issue? Which institutions in the Panchayati Raj can help you? What can the students do?

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Grassroots Democracy – Part 3

Local Government in Urban Areas

I desire that ... a full-fledged local body should be immediately formed, ... so that people may know really what is an administration, what are the franchise, what are the powers, what are the rights and what are the privileges in a small sphere, in their own town, in their own villages.

— Rustom K. Sidhwa, Member, Constituent Assembly
(during the Constituent Assembly Debates, 13 October 1949)

Fig. 12.1. The Municipal Corporation of Greater Mumbai (originally 'Bombay Municipal Corporation') was created in 1865.



The **Big**
Questions ?

1. What are urban local bodies and what are their functions?
2. Why are they important in governance and democracy?



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Introduction



Earlier chapters have shown us how, in a democracy, good governance aims to empower the citizens so they may actively participate in their country's functioning, whether it is at the rural, regional, urban, state or national level. This is the broader concept of **participatory democracy**.

We saw the basics of the system in a rural context. Let us now see how it works in an urban scenario. Since the latter is generally more complex

and diverse than the former, it is understandable that the urban governance system needs to be more complex too. We will however limit ourselves here to its basic principles.

LET'S EXPLORE



- Why is a city like Kolkata, Chennai or Mumbai more complex and diverse than a village or a town?
- With your classmates, make a list of diverse communities residing in any city that you are familiar with. How many were you able to list? What else do you observe in the list?

Before we explore governance and administration in urban areas, it helps to take an overall look at the Indian system of governance, from rural to national, as depicted in Fig. 12.2 on page 175. The base of the pyramid is the local level, closer to the people, while the top is the national level. In Chapter 11, we explored the left side of the pyramid; we will now take a look at the right side.

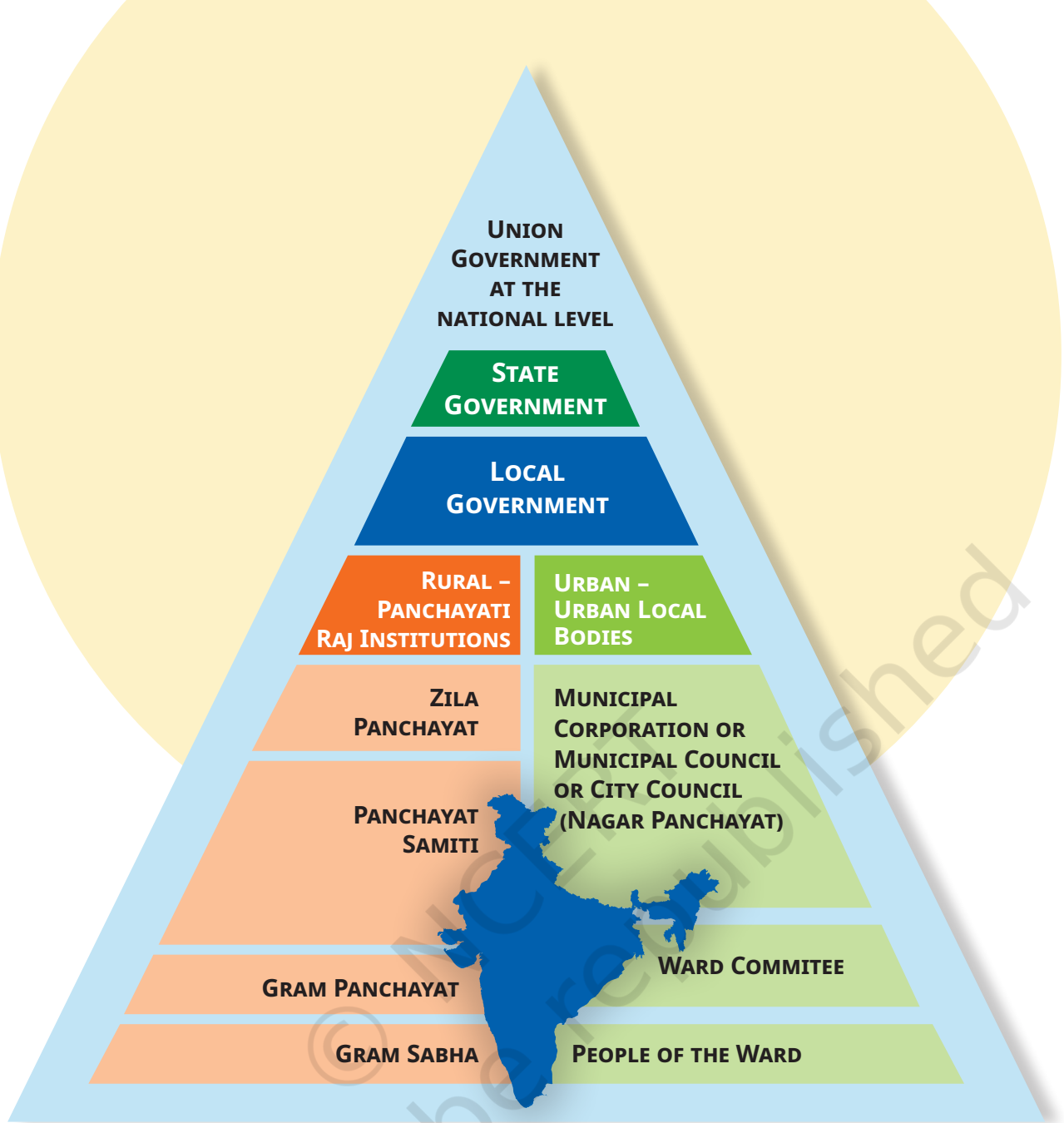


Fig. 12.2

LET'S EXPLORE

In Fig. 12.2 above, what similarities and differences do you notice between the Panchayati Raj system and the urban local government?

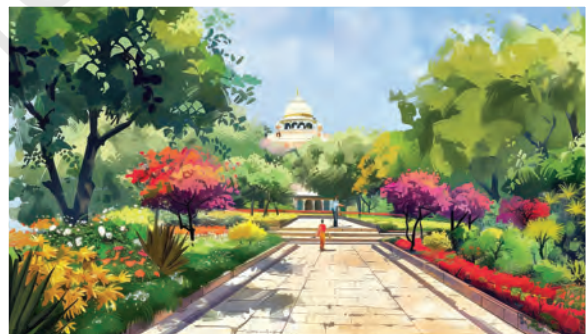


Urban Local Bodies

Local government structures in urban areas are called 'urban local bodies'. They are decentralised, which means that instead of operating under a central authority at the

top, the local communities have a direct say on how their areas are managed or the issues they face. It is a mechanism for citizens living in an area to come together and take decisions about what is best for them.

Cities and towns are divided into smaller units called 'wards', and the ward committees facilitate activities such as conducting health camps, organising a campaign against the use of single-use plastics, and so on. They also keep an eye on anything that might go wrong — a water leak, a blocked drain, a damaged road, etc. — and report such problems to the authorities. However, the precise functioning of wards differs from State to State, depending on the rules they make.



Altogether, urban local bodies are responsible for a range of functions — helping take care of the infrastructure, maintaining the burial ground, garbage collection and disposal, checking the implementation of government schemes, collecting local taxes and fines, and so on. They also have some role in planning for the area's economic and social development. However, for these bodies to be

able to perform their functions efficiently, people living in the city must also perform their duties, which means that they must show care and concern for their area (remember, this is a **participatory** democracy). For instance, if people carefully follow instructions regarding waste segregation, garbage collection becomes easier; or if they notice a water leakage in a street, reporting it promptly will prevent further wastage of precious water.

LET'S EXPLORE

Can you think of four or five more actions that responsible citizens might take to help their area of the city?



Fig. 12.3. The Madras Corporation

The Madras Corporation (now Greater Chennai Corporation), established on 29 September 1688, is the oldest municipal institution in India. The East India Company issued a charter the previous year constituting the town of 'Fort St. George' and all territories within 16 km from the Fort into a corporation. A Parliamentary Act of 1792 gave the Madras Corporation power to levy municipal taxes in the city, which is when the municipal administration properly began.

SERVICES UNDER THE INDORE MUNICIPAL CORPORATION			
			
PROPERTY TAX	WATER CHARGES	SOLID WASTE MANAGEMENT	BUSINESS, HOARDINGS, TRADE LICENSES
			
CRM* — MARRIAGE CERTIFICATE	CRM — FIRE SERVICES	CRM — VARIOUS LICENSES	CRM — WATER TANKER, DEBRIS CLEARANCE
			
TREE CUTTING & TREE TRANSPORTATION	CRM — GRIEVANCES		
CRM — SERVICES ON REQUEST			
			
Water Tanker	Septic Tanker	Auditorium	Funeral Van
			
Mobile Toilet		Ambulance	

*CRM: Citizen Relationship Management.

(The list of services offered by the Indore Municipal Corporation is simplified here.)

Fig. 12.4. Services under the Indore Municipal Corporation



THINK ABOUT IT

Indore in Madhya Pradesh has been awarded the cleanest city in India under the *Swachh Survekshan* government scheme for seven years in a row. What could have been the role of Indore citizens in this achievement?

As we see, Chennai and Indore have a Municipal Corporation at the top of their urban bodies. Only cities with a population above 10 lakhs have a Municipal Corporation (also called 'Mahanagar Nigam') as their highest body. Between 1 and 10 lakhs, the highest body is a Municipal Council (also called 'Nagar Palika'). Cities and towns with smaller populations have a Nagar Panchayat.

LET'S EXPLORE

- Select a few cities, from your State and from a few neighbouring States. These may include the city you live in or the city nearest to your town or village. How will you find out if they have a Nagar Panchayat, Municipal Council or Municipal Corporation? Draw a table with the names of the cities and the type of urban local body each of them has.
- How do urban local bodies fund their activities? (*Hint: Look carefully at the pictures of the functions performed by Indore Municipal Corporation in Figure 12.4 on page 178.*) Are some of them paid services?

Sameer: Hello! I haven't seen you around here before. Are you new to this village?

Anita: Hello! Yes, I'm visiting my grandparents who live nearby. I am from the city. It's quite different from here!

Sameer: Oh, really? What's it like in the city?



Anita: Well, it's busy and crowded, with tall buildings everywhere. There are so many people rushing around all the time, and it's noisy compared to the quietness here. Also, people are more independent and often don't even know their neighbours.

Sameer: Wow! Here, everyone knows everyone else and pitches in to help each other out — we work together in the fields, celebrate festivals together, and even make decisions as a community.



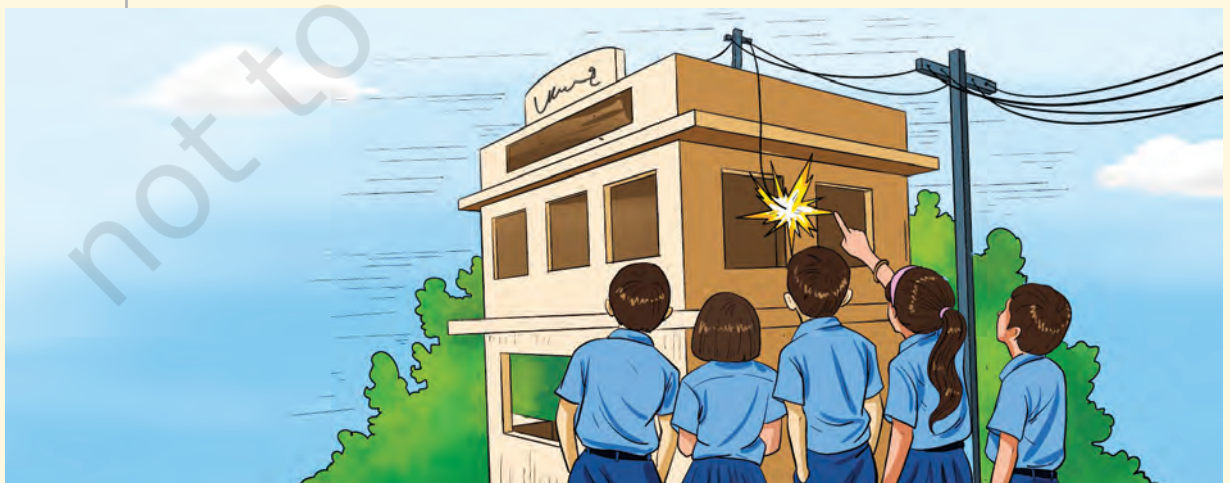
Anita: Well, there's still some sense of community in the city. Just the other day, following heavy rains, a house collapsed two streets away. Dozens of people gathered from all over the place to help clear the rubble and make sure no one was trapped inside.

Sameer: Doesn't the local government help in such cases?

Anita: Yes, it does. In fact, we have local bodies and elected representatives who represent us and our interests.

Sameer: Well, it sounds like our village Panchayat, only bigger. Members are elected, too, but because they all know each other, a lot more people can participate and discuss all kinds of issues that concern the village. Sometimes, even us kids can get heard.

Anita: Really? You are not making that up?



Sameer: Not at all! The other day a few kids noticed that an electricity wire was hanging dangerously low, almost touching the roof of a building. Not only did we report it, but we explained to one of our Gram Sabha members that an electric post should be shifted a little. And it was done!

Anita: Great! I suppose that's how democracy should work. It seems more complicated in the city, but the idea is the same — everyone's voice matters.

Sameer: Yes, it does! Sorry, I must make a move. My mother needs my help for a little shopping. Thanks for telling me about the city.

Anita: And thanks for telling me about your village! I am definitely going to look around.

Sameer: Well, maybe we'll meet again sometime. Bye!

Before we move on ...

- In urban areas, decentralised governance works through different urban local bodies, which fulfil various functions affecting the citizens' lives.
- As with the rural context, urban local bodies have elected members who represent the local citizens.
- The citizens also have duties to ensure that the local bodies are able to perform their functions efficiently.



Questions, activities and projects

1. On your way to school, you and your friends notice that a water pipe is leaking. A lot of water is being wasted on account of the leak. What would you and your friends do in such a situation?
2. Invite a member of an urban local body near you to your class. Discuss with them their role and responsibilities. Prepare a set of questions to ask them so that the meeting is fruitful.

3. Discuss with adult members of your family and neighbourhood, and make a list of their expectations from the urban local bodies.
4. Make a list of characteristics of a good urban local body.
5. What are the similarities and differences between the Panchayati Raj system in rural areas and the urban local bodies?

Noodles

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*'Noodles' is our abbreviation for 'Notes and Doodles'!